

Hyraxes

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Hyracoidea
FAMILIES	1 (Procaviidae)
SPECIES	5

Although **hyraxes resemble** rabbits in size and shape, genetic evidence suggests that they are more closely related to primitive hoofed mammals. The pads of their feet are moistened by glandular secretions, which make the soles more adhesive. This, along with the opposable toe on each back foot, enables hyraxes to climb steep rock faces. They are found in Africa and parts of the Middle East. Some species inhabit rocky outcrops; others are arboreal. They can survive food shortages because they eat almost every type of vegetation and require very little water (their kidneys are highly efficient).

KEEPING WARM
Hyraxes have poor temperature control. These rock hyraxes are huddling together for warmth.



Procavia capensis

Rock hyrax



Location W., S., and E. Africa, W. Asia
Social unit Group
Status Least concern

Length 15½–23 in (39–58 cm)
Tail 8–12 in (20–31 cm)
Weight 4–12 lb (1.8–5.4 kg)



The rock hyrax has a plump body and short, dense, gray or gray-brown fur, which is paler below. Also called the rock dassie, it lives in colonies of up to 80 individuals, usually of one dominant male, other males, and females and young. Although found in a wide variety of habitats, it usually lives in rocky outcrops and crags, among boulders, where it makes a grass-lined nest.



Dendrohyrax arboreus

Southern tree hyrax



Location E. and southern Africa
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Length 12½–23½ in (32–60 cm)
Tail ¾–1¼ in (1–3 cm)
Weight 3¼–10 lb (1.7–4.5 kg)



The southern tree hyrax or tree dassie has a yellowish patch on the back near the rump, but is otherwise gray-brown with buff underparts. The head, legs, and tail seem almost too small for the stocky body. True to its name, the southern tree hyrax lives among trees, shrubs, and creepers, and nests in a tree hole. It feeds on the ground only occasionally. Like all hyraxes, this species has poor control of body temperature, so groups often sunbathe to warm up, or rest in shade to cool down. Litters of 1–2 are born after a gestation period of 7–8 months.

Armadillos

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Cingulata
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	21

Instantly recognized by their protective armorlike covering of hardened skin on their head, back, sides, and limbs, and reduced fur, armadillos are ground-living animals allied to anteaters and sloths. They have simple peglike teeth and short, strong limbs for digging. They also have unusual special

articulations of the lower vertebral column (a feature shared with nonburrowing anteaters and sloths), which may be an adaptation for burrowing. Armadillos are mainly insect-eaters, but also eat a wide range of other items, including plant materials, eggs, and carrion. Most species occur in open habitats of South America, but one can also be found in the United States.

ARMADILLOS
Contrary to popular belief, not all armadillos can roll in a ball to defend themselves. Only species of the genus *Tolypeutes* can do this.



Priodontes maximus

Giant armadillo



Location N. and C. South America
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable

Length 30–39 in (75–100 cm)
Tail 20 in (50 cm)
Weight 41½–71¼ lb (18.7–32.3 kg)



By far the largest armadillo, this species has 11–13 bands of slightly flexible, hinged plates over its body, and 3–4 bands over its neck. The long, tapering tail is likewise armored. The main body color is brown, with a pale

yellow-white head, tail, and band along the lower edges of the plates. The especially large third front claw is used to rip up soil for small food items—mainly termites, ants, worms, spiders, small snakes, and lizards. The front claws also dig a burrow in which the giant armadillo shelters by day. It feeds in an area for 2–3 weeks, then moves on. Like most other armadillos, it shows little social or territorial behavior. The gestation period is 4 months, and the 1–2 offspring are weaned by 6 weeks and are sexually mature by 12 months.

